Seven Straight

S&P +0.61% to 6,824 — seventh consecutive gain. Ceasefire fraying but holding. Oil back above $100. Core PCE at 3.0%. Jobless claims rise.

THE SESSION

The S&P 500 extended its winning streak to seven sessions, adding 0.61% to close at 6,824. It was a measured advance rather than Wednesday's relief surge — the kind of follow-through that typically distinguishes a sustainable recovery from a one-day short squeeze. The Nasdaq gained 0.81%, the Dow added 0.58%, and the Russell 2000 climbed 0.60%. The VIX fell 7.3% to 19.50, settling back toward its long-term average for the first time since the conflict began in late February.

The session digested two crosscurrents simultaneously. On one hand, the ceasefire was visibly fraying: Iran's parliamentary speaker accused Washington of violating three of Tehran's ten conditions, Hezbollah claimed responsibility for overnight rocket strikes on northern Israel, and WTI climbed back above $100 as the Strait of Hormuz remained effectively closed despite the deal. On the other, economic data landed benignly: February's core PCE matched expectations at 3.0% year-over-year, ticking down from 3.1% in January, while headline PCE held at 2.8%. The Q4 GDP third estimate came in softer. Jobless claims rose to 219,000, above the 210,000 forecast, suggesting a labor market that is cooling at the edges but not breaking.

The market's ability to absorb rising oil, a deteriorating ceasefire narrative, and slightly soft labor data while still posting gains speaks to the positioning reset that Wednesday's relief rally initiated. Short interest unwinds and systematic re-risking carried the index through the 200-day moving average at 6,651 and past the 50-day at 6,771, closing above both for the first time since mid-March. Israel's announcement that it will pursue direct negotiations with Lebanon introduced a potential diplomatic channel that did not exist 48 hours ago, even as Beirut pushed back with "no negotiations under fire."

IOWN Tactical: The S&P sits 3.1% below its January high of 7,002. The ceasefire's durability remains the near-term variable, but the seven-session streak confirms that participants are repricing toward normalization rather than escalation. Portfolios constructed around cash-generative businesses do not require predicting which outcome materializes.

IOWN HOLDINGS: NOTABLE MOVERS

WINNERS

LRCX +4.99% — DIVIDEND STRATEGY

Led the portfolio on continued semiconductor momentum. Cantor Fitzgerald conference remarks on AI-driven demand catalyzed a 9.5% surge this week. Earnings due April 22.

HUT +3.24% — GROWTH PORTFOLIO

Bitcoin's move above $72,100 lifted the mining complex. HUT traded in a wide range ($60.55–$67.08 intraday) as crypto participated in the broader risk-on positioning.

TEL +2.51% — DIVIDEND STRATEGY

Connector demand tied to data center buildout and EV electrification continues to support the name. TE Connectivity reports April 22 alongside LRCX.

CAT +2.01% — DIVIDEND STRATEGY

Industrial bellwether advanced on infrastructure spending confidence as the ceasefire narrative supported global growth expectations. IRG secured a 1.38M sq. ft. lease in Joliet, IL.

AMD +2.07% — GROWTH PORTFOLIO

Semiconductor strength broadened beyond equipment names. Meta's expanded $21B CoreWeave AI partnership reinforced demand visibility for data center processors.

DECLINERS

FINV –3.87% — GROWTH PORTFOLIO

Chinese fintech sold off as PDD (−3.08%) led a broader pullback in China-linked ADRs. Tariff uncertainty and ceasefire ambiguity weighed on cross-border risk appetite.

COIN –3.42% — GROWTH PORTFOLIO

Gave back despite Bitcoin's advance. The divergence reflects profit-taking in crypto equities after Wednesday's surge rather than a fundamental shift.

FTNT –3.41% — GROWTH PORTFOLIO

Cybersecurity names broadly pressured as sector rotation continued. CrowdStrike led the downdraft after the initial Anthropic AI enthusiasm faded.

SSNC –3.03% — DIVIDEND STRATEGY

Software sector rotation and AI disruption concerns pushed SS&C to 52-week low territory. Morningstar recently downgraded its moat rating from narrow to none.

ADP –2.36% — DIVIDEND STRATEGY

Payroll giant continued its slide on labor market softening signals. Shares have declined over 30% from their 52-week high as investors reassess the premium valuation amid flat pays-per-control growth.

HOLDINGS NEWS

LRCX earnings call scheduled April 22. Lam Research announced it will host its quarterly financial conference call on April 22. Ahead of the report, B. Riley raised its price target to $310 citing accelerating HBM capex, while Morgan Stanley lifted to $260. The stock sits 4.5% below its February high.

CL faces tariff margin scrutiny. Colgate-Palmolive drew analyst attention on whether tariff-driven input cost pressures will compress its 2026 margin outlook. The stock added 0.57% today, suggesting the market views the risk as manageable at current levels.

CVX pulled back on energy reversal. Chevron fell 1.31% as funds unwound crisis-premium positions following Wednesday's 13% oil decline. Vista Investment Partners initiated a new $4.7M position in a related name, suggesting institutional buyers are using the pullback constructively.

PORTFOLIO PERFORMANCE

DIVIDEND STRATEGY ✓ BEAT BOTH

+0.51%

vs. DVY +0.20% | IWS +0.20%

GROWTH PORTFOLIO ✗ TRAIL

–0.17%

vs. IUSG +0.74%

YEAR-TO-DATE

Dividend +9.42% vs DVY +8.74% / IWS +7.88%
Growth +2.14% vs IUSG –1.95%